

Personas and Journey Maps

After being released in the morning, Sylvia and Ben started the three hour drive back into town. Sylvia yawned hugely, trying to shake herself into something that resembled being alert. She and Ben had had to spend the night at the military hospital and had been woken up repeatedly by nurses checking on them. Ben told her she was just imagining things, but Sylvia swore she heard moans that sounded like zombies several times. She knew her paranoia was likely a result of her traumatic experience coupled with her slight concussion, but she could not seem to intellectualize it and kept waking with her heart racing at every small sound.

They were told they would be allowed to interview the remaining members of the team that had handled the weapon in a day or two. One of the team members had died immediately, and another was in a coma, with severe burns and multiple fractures. The others were in bad shape but willing to talk.

Sylvia yawned again.

“Stop that! It’s catching!” said Ben, yawning with her.

“I can’t help it. I’m thrashed.” Sylvia said. “Maybe we can talk through what we’ve got so we have something cogent by the time we get to the office tomorrow.”

“Good idea. Although,” Ben paused, “I’m not sure I can think about anything except getting a shower at this point.”

Sylvia chuckled, “Yeah, we are pretty ripe.”

Ben sighed. “You’re in Uptown, right?”

Sylvia nodded.

“Perfect,” Ben said. “You’re less than five minutes from me. Would you mind picking me up tomorrow morning on the way in?” he gestured at his sling.

“No problem—that would be great!” she said, and meant it. She didn’t like the idea of driving into the office by herself. She wondered if Ben felt the same or if it was just his broken arm.

“Now, where should we start? We need to help the team understand and consume what we’ve done as quickly as possible. Some of our findings are going to affect the stories they’re building significantly.”

Ben agreed. “Well, we need to share that the operator has little knowledge of the weapon but loads of understanding of the situation. And that the weapon isn’t super-heavy, but the targeting system that we have to integrate with is.” He flipped through her notes and his own, continuing to list findings that were significant.

“I think we need to start with some personas. To get some clarity on who is using this thing and how,” Ben said when they finished the review.

“Hmmm...,” Sylvia considered. “Honestly, can’t we just do a regular report? Personas are so...fake.”

“I disagree,” Ben countered. “They’ll be the fastest way to get the team up to speed on who we’re building this for. I know they can be super-hokey when they’ve got, you know, like three cats and a hamster named Bubba, but that’s not the kind of thing I’m talking about here,” he paused, and winked at her. “Unless of course there’s a hamster ownership angle I missed.”

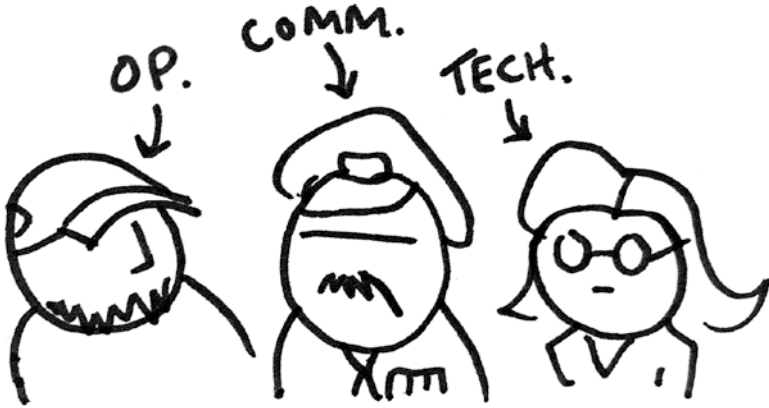
Sylvia laughed, switching lanes. “OK, I’ll admit that I have a serious distaste for the goofy bits that always seems to find their way in. But also, doing real personas well takes a ton of data! I mean, we’ve barely got enough to generalize a bit, let alone give the details we need, like tech savviness, adaptability, and so on, with any confidence.”

Ben nodded. “Fair point. However, we *do* have enough to give a rough idea of some of those things. These are really proto-personas. They’re not fully fleshed out, based off the limited data we have available, but they’re enough to give our stories characters that are more realistic than what we ‘think’ is the truth. As you know, this is a pretty specialized character we’re talking about here for a very particular tool. They’re not intended to be statistically representative of a population. They just need to be detailed enough to help the designers make choices. To give them some characters for the stories.”

Sighing, Sylvia had to agree. “Alright, we can do personas. Or proto-personas. But with a ton of caveats about accuracy and no cats. Or names. Once a persona gets a name, it tends to take on a life of its own, and everyone forgets they are just constructs, not data made incarnate.”

It was Ben’s turn to laugh. “Agreed. No cats. Roles and titles only. And stick figures, no stock photos. That makes them ‘just real enough’ to move the story along without anyone getting attached to them.”

They got to work reviewing their notes, Ben reading them aloud so Sylvia could comment. They looked for key characteristics for each role, ignoring anything about the person that wasn’t relevant to the work. They were almost to Ben’s apartment by the time they had sketched out three primary personas: the commander, the technician, and the squad member. As they pulled up to his security door, Ben showed them to her.



“I like them,” she said. She yawned again. “Pick you up at 7 tomorrow?”

“Yep, that’ll work. Go home and take a nap—and a shower!” Ben laughed and got out of the car as the security door flashed green. Sylvia watched the door shut behind him and then pulled away, heading to her own apartment. As she pulled up, she could see the walkway from the garage to the apartment was disabled again—probably another issue with the scanners. She parked in the enclosed garage and walked to the street door. Once there, she pushed her door clicker. The hum of the area scanner sounded as a blue light fanned out, scanning a perimeter of 50 yards for zombies. The door lit up green. Sylvia let out a breath she didn’t know she’d been holding and quickly ran the short distance from the garage to the apartment. The bang of the heavy metal door behind her was far more comforting than it should have been.

Well after dark, feeling much better after a shower and some leftover dumplings, Sylvia leaned back looking at her laptop screen. She’d taken a nap to try to make up for the restless night, and it had helped, but now she was wide awake.

Fortunately, Ben had called with a question about one of her notes, and they had ended up talking through more of the results over the phone. One of the tricky things they would need to get across was the steps someone had to go through before and after a decision was made to initiate a zombie removal. They decided on a rough journey map to show where some of the unexpected issues arose. Sylvia had protested at first, citing that a good journey map takes time and more observations than just the one that they had. But Ben had made the point that they weren't going to have any other data coming in since the one prototype had blown up and it would be useful to help the designers identify the gaps in the experience quickly. In the end, Sylvia had agreed, and they had poured over their notes together to create the map. They chose to have the map start at the point the decision was made to engage with some zombies. The transportation issue and movement were captured as well as the need for off-site storage. Sylvia wasn't completely satisfied with it. It didn't capture the difficulties of use in a combat situation. But, a journey map wasn't the best way to deliver that information. A straightforward presentation of findings would do that. And one look at her control panel sketch would be enough to get across how maddeningly complex the system was.

After she hung up with Ben, she reviewed what they had done and made some tweaks. She had to grudgingly admit that both the personas and journey map were more consumable than the reports she usually provided. She still had reservations about their misuse, but she understood that when time was tight, it might make the difference between someone benefiting from the research that had been done and ignoring it.

It was well after midnight when she finally shut her laptop, eyes drooping. It had been an intense couple of days. She was a bit surprised at how quickly they had been able to bring the results together. But she still wasn't convinced it would be helpful.

Key Takeaways

- Personas represent a way of thinking about the user that is more “real” than looking at data in a table. Good personas are created using an aggregate of data from multiple observations of real users. Bad personas are created based on assumptions about what you think users are like. For more information on how to create personas, see Shlomo Goltz's “A Closer Look at Personas: What They Are and How They Work Parts 1 and 2,” August 6, 2014, <https://www.smashingmagazine.com/2014/08/a-closer-look-at-personas-part-1/> and <https://www.usability.gov/how-to-and-tools/methods/personas.html>.

- Proto-personas represent the first step toward creating full personas. They are useful when you have limited observations but need to move quickly. For more information on proto-personas, see Todd Elliott's "Avoiding Half-baked Personas," January 11, 2011, <http://adaptivepath.org/ideas/avoiding-half-baked-personas/>.
- It is important to note the difference between a persona and a segmentation. A persona is a tool—explicitly not defined by quantified characteristics—that aids in the design process. As such, they are not a rigorous research artifact and should not be treated as such. A segmentation study divides target consumers into specific groups. These studies rely on quantifiable characteristics that can be clustered, that is, grouped together statistically. For more information on segmentation studies, see Gretchen Gavett's "What You Need to Know About Segmentation," Harvard Business Review, July, 2014, <https://hbr.org/2014/07/what-you-need-to-know-about-segmentation>.
- Personas are important when creating stories. They provide the actor/character for the story and help keep the solution focused on the appropriate role. In addition, with sufficient data, they can provide insight into how different roles overlap, which can be key in creating efficiencies within a workflow. Personas help distance the user of the product from the reader (designer, developer, product manager, etc.), helping keep in mind the mantra that "you are not your user." Without personas, stories often default to using "the user" as the actor, which leads to confusion later as the team begins to lose focus on who, exactly, "the user" is.
- Journey maps are a graphical story tool used to convey the totality of the customer journey outside their touch points with the tool or software. Researchers use journey maps to communicate opportunities, issues, and patterns—to educate the rest of the company about the customer's experience in a way that doesn't focus on which button they clicked first. Using journey maps ensures that the team sees segments of the user's experience in their entirety. For more details on how to work with journey maps, see Megan Grocki's "How to Create a Customer Journey

Map,” September 16, 2014, <http://uxmastery.com/how-to-create-a-customer-journey-map/>, as well as Paul Boag’s “All You Need to Know about Customer Journey Mapping,” January 15, 2015, *Smashing Magazine*, <https://www.smashingmagazine.com/2015/01/all-about-customer-journey-mapping/>.